

Evaluation Methodology & Grading Rubric

CPS Metrics & Cross-State Comparison – Team Working Document

Purpose: Use this shared document to decide how we will evaluate states, calculate grades, handle missing data, and identify legislators for recognition. Add ideas as we work and update the final decisions after feedback from Alan/Jarred.

1. Evaluation Goal

What are we trying to measure about each state's child protection system?

- We want to measure how well each state's child protection system performs using child protection data that can be compared fairly across states. The evaluation should look at important areas such as reports, investigations, substantiations, removals, foster care use, and outcomes when the available data supports those comparisons.

What should the final evaluation tell the user?

- The final evaluation should show how each state performs in the selected areas, what grade the state receives, what data was used to determine that grade, any limitations that could affect the results. It should make it easy to understand where a state is doing well and where there may be areas for improvement.

2. Important Child-Protection Terms

Report: An allegation to a state CPS hotline or intake channel typically by any public member who suspects child abuse or neglect happening to the child.

Investigation: The official CPS procedure that follows the acceptance of a report and is used to determine if abuse or neglect has occurred, which typically involves contact with the child, the family and other sources.

Substantiation: A finding following investigation that the evidence meets the state's legal criteria for finding abuse or neglect, with different states using different criteria and terminology, including "substantiated," "founded," "indicated," or similar terms.

Removal: The legal process of removing a child from the home, usually by court order or in an emergency, and placing the child in foster care or another placement due to safety concerns.

3. Metrics We Will Use Important Child-Protection Terms

Which metrics should be included?

Why is each metric important?

4. State Grading System

What grading system will we use? (Example: A-F, score, categories)

What does each grade/category mean?

5. Grade Requirements & Metric Weights

What does a state need to earn each grade?

Should some metrics count more than others? If yes, how much?

6. Missing or Insufficient Data

What happens if a state does not have enough data?

When should we mark a state as not able to be graded?

7. Legislator Recognition

What should qualify a legislator for recognition?

What information/evidence should support the recognition?

8. Final Decisions / Sponsor Feedback

What did Alan/Jarred approve or ask us to change?

What questions still need to be answered?